ENGLISH C1 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Impersonal passive and stance

Use it-passives and subject-to-infinitive passives to report general beliefs, claims and expectations with controlled distance. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use impersonal passive and stance to manage attribution and information focus without erasing responsibility while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Use it-passives and subject-to-infinitive passives to report general beliefs, claims and expectations with controlled distance.

MODEL

The treatment is believed to reduce recovery time.

it + be + reporting participle + that | subject + be + reporting participle + to-infinitive

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main impersonal passive and stance patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses manage attribution and information focus without erasing responsibility.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in formal reports, news, academic review and institutional communication.

Build meaning before form

Use it-passives and subject-to-infinitive passives to report general beliefs, claims and expectations with controlled distance.

What impersonal passive and stance communicates

Use it-passives and subject-to-infinitive passives to report general beliefs, claims and expectations with controlled distance.

The central purpose is to manage attribution and information focus without erasing responsibility. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

It is widely believed that the treatment reduces recovery time.	a general reported belief with the proposition in focus
The treatment is believed to reduce recovery time.	the reported entity placed in subject position
The minister is alleged to have withheld the document.	a reported earlier action connected to a current allegation

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: it + be + reporting participle + that | subject + be + reporting participle + to-infinitive. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “The treatment is believed to reduce recovery time.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
It-passive	it + be + participle + that-clause	It is widely believed that the treatment reduces recovery time.
Subject raising	subject + be + participle + to-infinitive	The treatment is believed to reduce recovery time.
Earlier report	subject + be + participle + to have + participle	The minister is alleged to have withheld the document.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a general reported belief with the proposition in focus	It-passive
the reported entity placed in subject position	Subject raising
a reported earlier action connected to a current allegation	Earlier report

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in formal reports, news, academic review and institutional communication. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03	04	05	06	07	08
it	be	reporting participle	that	subject	be	reporting participle	to-infinitive

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: manage attribution and information focus without erasing responsibility.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits formal reports, news, academic review and institutional communication.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
It-passive	it + be + participle + that-clause	It is widely believed that the treatment reduces recovery time.
Subject raising	subject + be + participle + to-infinitive	The treatment is believed to reduce recovery time.
Earlier report	subject + be + participle + to have + participle	The minister is alleged to have withheld the document.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

It is widely believed that the treatment reduces recovery time.	a general reported belief with the proposition in focus
The treatment is believed to reduce recovery time.	the reported entity placed in subject position
The minister is alleged to have withheld the document.	a reported earlier action connected to a current allegation

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use an impersonal passive when the actual source must remain accountable.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Match the infinitive form to the reported time reference.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use a simple infinitive when the reported action clearly predates the reporting point.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a general reported belief with the proposition in focus?

OPTIONS It is widely believed that the treatment reduces recovery time. · The treatment is believed to reduce recovery time. · The minister is alleged to have withheld the document.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: the reported entity placed in subject position?

OPTIONS The treatment is believed to reduce recovery time. · The minister is alleged to have withheld the document. · It is widely believed that the treatment reduces recovery time.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a reported earlier action connected to a current allegation?

OPTIONS The minister is alleged to have withheld the document. · It is widely believed that the treatment reduces recovery time. · The treatment is believed to reduce recovery time.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “It is widely believed that the treatment reduces recovery time.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a general reported belief with the proposition in focus · the reported entity placed in subject position · a reported earlier action connected to a current allegation

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “The treatment is believed to reduce recovery time.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS the reported entity placed in subject position · a reported earlier action connected to a current allegation · a general reported belief with the proposition in focus

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “The minister is alleged to have withheld the document.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a reported earlier action connected to a current allegation · a general reported belief with the proposition in focus · the reported entity placed in subject position

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"It is widely believed that the treatment reduces recovery time." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: It-passive / Subject raising / Earlier report · Gap 2: a general reported belief with the proposition in focus / the reported entity placed in subject position / a reported earlier action connected to a current allegation

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"The treatment is believed to reduce recovery time." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Subject raising / Earlier report / It-passive · Gap 2: the reported entity placed in subject position / a reported earlier action connected to a current allegation / a general reported belief with the proposition in focus

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"The minister is alleged to have withheld the document." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Earlier report / It-passive / Subject raising · Gap 2: a reported earlier action connected to a current allegation / a general reported belief with the proposition in focus / the reported entity placed in subject position

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a general reported belief with the proposition in focus: _____. Choose the model that expresses the reported entity placed in subject position: _____. Choose the model that expresses a reported earlier action connected to a current allegation: _____. Choose the model built with it + be + participle + that-clause: _____. Choose the model built with subject + be + participle + to-infinitive: _____. Choose the model built with subject + be + participle + to have + participle: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

It is widely believed that the treatment reduces recovery time. · The minister is alleged to have withheld the document. · The treatment is believed to reduce recovery time.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

_____ that the treatment reduces recovery time. The treatment _____ recovery time. The minister _____ the document. State the full structural pattern for It-passive: _____. State the full structural pattern for Subject raising: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “Many people believe the treatment reduces recovery time.” using the It-passive pattern to express a general reported belief with the proposition in focus.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “People believe that the treatment reduces recovery time.” using the Subject raising pattern to express the reported entity placed in subject position.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “It is alleged that the minister withheld the document.” using the Earlier report pattern to express a reported earlier action connected to a current allegation.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “Many people believe the treatment reduces recovery time.” using the It-passive pattern to express a general reported belief with the proposition in focus.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use It-passive to express a general reported belief with the proposition in focus, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Subject raising to express the reported entity placed in subject position, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Earlier report to express a reported earlier action connected to a current allegation, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

It is widely believed that the treatment reduces recovery time.

It-passive is the best match because a general reported belief with the proposition in focus.

A2

The treatment is believed to reduce recovery time.

Subject raising is the best match because the reported entity placed in subject position.

A3

The minister is alleged to have withheld the document.

Earlier report is the best match because a reported earlier action connected to a current allegation.

A4

a general reported belief with the proposition in focus

The It-passive pattern communicates a general reported belief with the proposition in focus.

A5

the reported entity placed in subject position

The Subject raising pattern communicates the reported entity placed in subject position.

A6

a reported earlier action connected to a current allegation

The Earlier report pattern communicates a reported earlier action connected to a current allegation.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

It-passive / a general reported belief with the proposition in focus

The structure belongs to the It-passive pattern. Its communicative purpose is a general reported belief with the proposition in focus.

B2

Subject raising / the reported entity placed in subject position

The structure belongs to the Subject raising pattern. Its communicative purpose is the reported entity placed in subject position.

B3

Earlier report / a reported earlier action connected to a current allegation

The structure belongs to the Earlier report pattern. Its communicative purpose is a reported earlier action connected to a current allegation.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

It is widely believed that the treatment reduces recovery time.

It-passive: it + be + participle + that-clause.

C2

The treatment is believed to reduce recovery time.

Subject raising: subject + be + participle + to-infinitive.

C3

The minister is alleged to have withheld the document.

Earlier report: subject + be + participle + to have + participle.

C4

It is widely believed that the treatment reduces recovery time.

It-passive: it + be + participle + that-clause.

C5

The treatment is believed to reduce recovery time.

Subject raising: subject + be + participle + to-infinitive.

C6

The minister is alleged to have withheld the document.

Earlier report: subject + be + participle + to have + participle.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

It is widely believed

It-passive requires “It is widely believed” in this model. it + be + participle + that-clause.

D2

is believed to reduce

Subject raising requires “is believed to reduce” in this model. subject + be + participle + to-infinitive.

D3

is alleged to have withheld

Earlier report requires “is alleged to have withheld” in this model. subject + be + participle + to have + participle.

D4

it + be + participle + that-clause

It-passive is built as it + be + participle + that-clause.

D5

subject + be + participle + to-infinitive

Subject raising is built as subject + be + participle + to-infinitive.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

It is widely believed that the treatment reduces recovery time.

it + be + participle + that-clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended it-passive effect.

E2

The treatment is believed to reduce recovery time.

subject + be + participle + to-infinitive. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended subject raising effect.

E3

The minister is alleged to have withheld the document.

subject + be + participle + to have + participle. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended earlier report effect.

E4

It is widely believed that the treatment reduces recovery time.

it + be + participle + that-clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended it-passive effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

It is widely believed that the treatment reduces recovery time. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses it + be + participle + that-clause accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

The treatment is believed to reduce recovery time. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses subject + be + participle + to-infinitive accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

The minister is alleged to have withheld the document. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses subject + be + participle + to have + participle accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____